
COURTLY CULTURE UNDER BABUR AND THE EARLY MUGHALS

Author(s): STEPHEN P. BLAKE

Source: *Journal of Asian History*, 1986, Vol. 20, No. 2 (1986), pp. 193-214

Published by: Harrassowitz Verlag

Stable URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/41931994>

JSTOR is a not-for-profit service that helps scholars, researchers, and students discover, use, and build upon a wide range of content in a trusted digital archive. We use information technology and tools to increase productivity and facilitate new forms of scholarship. For more information about JSTOR, please contact support@jstor.org

Your use of the JSTOR archive indicates your acceptance of the Terms & Conditions of Use, available at <https://about.jstor.org/terms>



Harrassowitz Verlag is collaborating with JSTOR to digitize, preserve and extend access to *Journal of Asian History*

JSTOR

STEPHEN P. BLAKE
(University of Minnesota)

COURTLY CULTURE UNDER BABUR AND THE EARLY MUGHALS

In Mughal India high culture centered on the imperial court. Emperors, princes, and great amirs perfected a highly-refined cultural idiom that included mastery of the arts both of peace and of war. These men also patronized a talented group of specialists who, under their direction and inspiration, set new standards for the courtly arts of the day.

Although this high cultural style probably peaked under the emperor Shahjahan (1628–56), its roots can be traced back to Babur, the first Mughal emperor, and beyond. The descendants of Timur, the great Turkic-Mongol ruler of the late fourteenth and early fifteenth centuries, were extremely proficient in the arts and became, as warriors and poets, early exemplars of the cultural style that was to reign in India.

Although the culture of the Mughal court, practiced by the seventy to one hundred high-ranking amirs and the artists and artisans they patronized, was not in complete conformity with the *sharia* (Islamic law code), it strayed no further from the religious ideal than had the courtly styles of earlier Islamic states. In fact, from about 750 A. D., when the capital of the Abbasid state shifted from Damascus to Baghdad and Persians began to fill positions of governmental responsibility, Muslim divines had criticized rulers and their courts for departing from the path of true discipline. Rulers of the Seljuk, Mongol, Safavid, and Ottoman states, for example, had all been censured for impurity and apostasy.

Akbar's attempts to broaden his base of support and to create an ethic that would appeal to the indigenous elite was similar to the efforts of the Abbasid ruler al-Mansur to include Persians in his Arab-dominated state, and to the policies of the Seljuks and Il-Khanids, Turkic and Mongol rulers respectively, to fashion a system that would gain local support. For the Seljuks and Il-Khanids in Iran it was the rulers rather than the conquered who were "Persianized and Islamicized"; nevertheless, it is clear that Akbar's creation of a state system broad enough to include the non-Muslim elite was not unknown in Islamic history.

High culture in Mughal India then, if not strictly orthodox, was certainly in accordance with accommodations made by other Muslim dynasties to the demands of successful ruling. In the arts both of peace and of war the basic style was a blending of Hindu and Muslim elements into an Indo-Muslim or Indo-Persian composite. By the Mughal period the basic elements of this style had been established and the syncretistic nature of the arts had become accepted.

The high culture of the imperial court was paradigmatic for *mansabdars* (office-holders), administrators, and cavalymen. Emperors, princes, and great amirs displayed their skills at court and on the battlefield, manifesting the ideal of the fully cultured man. This ideal combined the two professional types of the Islamic world: *ahl-i qalam* (men of the pen) and *ahl-i saif* (men of the sword). Men of the pen were clerks, accountants, supervisors, treasurers, and revenue collectors. Men of the sword were commanders, cavalymen, and troopers. By their wit and polish, their eloquence and style, their stamina, courage, and strength, and their skills with horses, guns, and swords, the great men set standards for both groups of men and, combining them in a graceful and commanding way, embodied the ideal against which they had to measure themselves and toward which they had to aspire.

In the Islamic world "men of the sword" and "men of the pen" had been recognized as distinct classes for a long time. In the mid-eleventh century Ibn Miskawaih distinguished the two groups in an Arabic work entitled *Tahdhib al-Akhlaq*. But it was *Akhlaq-i Nasiri*, a work on ethics by Nasir al-Din Tusi that was the most influential. Composed in 1235 A. D. in Persian, it soon became required reading for educated Muslims in West Asia and India. In the section "On the Government of the Realm and the Manners of Kings," Tusi stated that an emperor's first duty was to maintain harmony among the four classes of mankind: (1) men of the pen, masters of the sciences and branches of knowledge – canon-lawyers, judges, secretaries, accountants, geometers, astronomers, physicians, and poets; (2) men of the sword, supporters of the realm and guardians of the state – fighters, warriors, volunteers, skirmishers, frontier-guards, sentries, and valiant men; (3) men of negotiation – merchants, tradesmen, craftsmen, and tax-collectors; and (4) men of husbandry – sowers, farmers, ploughmen, and agriculturalists.¹

¹ Nasir al-Din Tusi, *The Nasirean Ethics*, trans. G. M. Wickens (London, George Allen and Unwin, Ltd., 1964), p. 230.

Soon after, manuals outlining the duties of the "men of the pen" and the "men of the sword" began to appear. Books by Ibn al-Wardi (d. 1349) and Ibn Nubata (d. 1366) in the fourteenth century were followed by a number of similar works in the first half of the fifteenth century.² In the early fifteenth century al-Qalqashandi completed an encyclopedia for "men of the pen," giving sample letters and documents and including a great deal of information on religion, history, and society.³

Ibn Khaldun analyzed the role of the two groups in the evolution of states. In his monumental history, finished in the first years of the fifteenth century, he stated that "men of the sword" were dominant at the founding and the collapse of dynasties. In the beginning, soldiers are crucial in establishing power and securing peace and order and are favored over administrators and secretaries. At the end, when group feeling has weakened and the state is tottering, the military again becomes ascendant. It is during the middle years, when rulers are established, that "men of the pen" gain the upper hand. They collect taxes and administer the law, rising to positions of power and authority and eclipsing the "men of the sword."⁴

Such concepts were widespread in Mughal India. In his preface to the *A'in*, Abu al-Fazl listed "men of the sword" and "men of the pen" among the four groups of mankind, taking his definitions and descriptions directly from Tusi. And *Akhlaq-i Nasiri* was one of the books most often read to the emperor Akbar.⁵

Men of the Pen

The great amir who embodied the high culture of the Mughal court had mastered the arts both of peace and of war. He combined the skills and talents of the men of the sword and the pen. In Mughal India, as in other parts of the Islamic world, there arose a class of writers, accountants,

² See *Encyclopaedia of Islam*, 2 d. ed. s. v. "kalam."

³ Marshall G. S. Hodgson, *The Venture of Islam*, I–III, (University of Chicago Press, 1974), II, 467.

⁴ Ibn Khaldun, *The Muqaddisma*, I–III, trans. Franz Rosenthal, (Princeton University Press, 1958), II, 46–47.

⁵ Abu al-Fazl, *Ain-i Akbari*, I–III, trans. H. Blochmann and H. S. Jarrett, (Calcutta, Asiatic Society of Bengal, 1868–94), I, 4, 110.

and administrators who performed the everyday functions of the state. These men, who developed their own culture and came to be called "men of the pen," had deep roots in Islamic history and can probably be traced to the Iranian scribes and administrators of the early Abbasid state.

The ancestors of the "men of the pen" were probably the *adibs* (possessors of *adab*). As developed in the high Abbasid period (ninth and tenth centuries A. D.), *adab* denoted the pattern of civilized living that had grown up around the imperial court in Baghdad. The court established standards for cultivated, civilized life and boasted the most elegant practitioners of the arts. At the beginning of Abbasid rule *adab* meant the civility, courtesy, and refinement of the cities in contrast to the rough and unsophisticated manners of the desert. *Adab* implied the sum of knowledge that makes a man courteous and urbane and included profane as well as religious learning. From the early Abbasid period onward the content of *adab* expanded to include elements from the many non-Arabic cultures (especially the Iranian) to which Muslims were exposed. As a result, by about the ninth century there had come into existence a body of *adab* literature centered on man, his qualities, passions, and environment; a literature whose mastery was indispensable for the cultured, civilized Muslim of West Asia.⁶

Adab culture was the province, for the most part, of the scribes, clerks, and managers who administered the Abbasid state. Unrelated to the great landed aristocratic families of Iran, these men traced their origins to low-ranking Arab families, newly-risen Iranian converts, and aspiring merchant families. The members of this class were urbane and cosmopolitan but, other than dedication to an administrative career, had little in common with one another.

For the *adib*, control of a language and its literature were of paramount importance. During the eighth through the tenth centuries mastery of spoken and written Arabic distinguished the cultured man at the caliphal court. Elegant speech, studded with historical allusions and fragments of poetry, was universally admired. An intimate knowledge of Arabic literature and a lucid, flowing prose style commanded praise.

⁶ *Encyclopedia of Islam*, 2 d. ed., s. v. "adab;" Ira M. Lapidus, "Knowledge, Virtue, and Action: The Classical Muslim Conception of *Adab* and the Nature of Religious Fulfillment in Islam," in Barbara Daly Metcalf, ed., *Moral Conduct and Authority: The Place of Adab in South Asian Islam*, (University of California Press, 1984), pp. 38–61.

Highly prized among courtiers was the ability to compose orders, diplomatic correspondence, and proclamations in a highly ornamented style. The purpose of the prose was to divert and entertain through sheer verbal virtuosity and to impart information about the world. Poetry, however, was king of the verbal arts. It was composed according to strict formal standards governing rhythm, rhyme, form, subject matter, and verbal usage and was chanted or sung in public. A faultless grip on the mechanics of Arabic was indispensable, and a detailed knowledge of Arabic grammar, syntax, and vocabulary was the bedrock of every *adib*'s education.

Other art forms also found a place in the courtly culture of West Asia. Rulers, nobles, and merchants patronized architects and lavished money on palaces, mansions, gardens, baths, tombs, and mosques. Painting did not develop a following until the later centuries, when the Persian influence had become quite strong. Following the Mongol conquest, painters in West and Central Asia were encouraged and patronized in courtly circles. Calligraphy emerged during this period as well. Several styles of handwriting were created and used to decorate books, mosques, and tombs. Finally, men of taste and refinement patronized woodworkers, metalworkers, weavers, rug-makers, potters, porcelain-makers, embroiders, and other skilled artisans.⁷

In Mughal India "men of the pen" were clerks, secretaries, accountants, revenue officials, and superintendents. They often held low ranks in the mansabdari system—20–200 zat—and filled administrative positions in the towns and cities that served as revenue circle, district, and provincial headquarters. In the imperial household they managed mints, arsenals, workshops, libraries, and storerooms. Other men held similar positions in the households of high-ranking amirs but because they were not in the imperial system they did not hold mansabdari ranks.

Some of these men were Muslim, immigrant administrators or Hindu converts, but most of the Mughal "men of the pen" seem to have come from the traditional Hindu writer and clerical castes. In North India these were the Kayasths and Khattris and in South India the Brahmans. Kayasths are thought to have been the first Hindu caste to learn Persian (in the early fifteenth century under Sikander Lodi) and, by the time of Akbar, had taken up positions throughout the empire. Khattris too

⁷ For a discussion of adab culture see Hodgson, *Venture*, I, 445–71.

learned Persian and soon became important managers and administrators in North India.⁸

Low-ranking mansabdars of the imperial household and unranked men of amiri establishments did not command high salaries. Revenue circle officials received 10–17 rupees a month (about the same as cavalrymen), district and provincial officials were paid perhaps 50–100 rupees per month, and managers in the imperial household earned no more than 500 rupees per month. Nevertheless, these men seem to have had unofficial sources of income and to have been able to support cultured and refined life-styles. They faked revenue records, remitting less than they collected; took in valuable coins and passed on damaged ones; deposited tax receipts with moneylenders, keeping the interest for themselves; and demanded bribes for fulfilling their duties.⁹

Mughal “men of the pen” mastered Persian, the language of the court, and during the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries produced works of history, poetry, and literature. They adopted Muslim dress and learned the behavior demanded by the court ceremonial. They had the resources to build beautiful homes and to patronize talented artists and skilled artisans.

“Men of the pen,” however, were not the principal practitioners of high culture during the Mughal period. The seventy to one hundred great amirs of the imperial court underwent a rigorous program of study and training that enabled them not only to master the basic skills of the “men of the pen” but also to extend and refine their abilities and talents and to express them in a new, beautiful, and striking way.

Unlike the largely Hindu “men of the pen,” the great amirs were predominantly Muslim and under Babur, Humayun, and Akbar mostly foreign. During the early years of Akbar’s reign, before the Rajput influx, the high-ranking nobility were about 70 per cent foreign and nearly 100 per cent Muslim. As a result, the education and training of the typical great amir had a substantial Islamic element. Every adult Muslim male was expected to be able to recite the basic creed, perform the

⁸ Aziz Ahmad, *Studies in Islamic Culture in the Indian Environment* (Oxford, Clarendon Press, 1964), pp. 105–07. For the Kayasths see Karen Isaksen Leonard, *Social History of an Indian Caste: The Kayasths of Hyderabad*, (University of California Press, 1978).

⁹ I. A. Khan, “The Middle Classes in the Mughal Empire,” *Proceedings: Indian History Congress*, (1975), pp. 113–41.

five prayers, and read, if not understand, the Quran. Sons of amirs had tutors for this early training while others studied in *maktabs* (small schools) or *madrasahs* (larger schools). The syllabus, developed in the late fifteenth century and revised and expanded in ca. 1600, was that of Sikander Lodi, and it directed Muslim education in India until about 1750.¹⁰

For the typical great amir schooling began at age four with the memorization of verses from the Quran. In order to understand the sacred book and the classical works of law and theology, the study of Arabic grammar, diction, and syntax followed. Then came Islamic law (*fiqh*) and the principles of jurisprudence. After this *tafsir* (exegesis of the Quran), *hadith* (traditions of the prophet), *kalam* (scholastic philosophy), and *mantiq* (logic) were begun.¹¹

Persian was the language of court and administration. Every educated man knew the *Gulistan* and *Bustan* of Sa'adi, the poems of Hafiz, and the *Shah-Namah* of Firdausi. In addition, great amirs learned to express themselves forcefully and eloquently, both in speech and in writing. Sikander Lodi's syllabus included *ma'ani* (rhetoric, the theory of literary style), *bayan* (clearness of speech), *badi* (beauty), *uruz* (prosody), *quwafi* (syllables), and *adab* (literature and learning).¹² Great men also studied mathematics, learned a bit about medicine, and practiced calligraphy. A refined and elegant hand was a valued accomplishment.

While Persian was the language of the Mughal state in administration and at court, it was never the native tongue of any but a handful of the elite. Except for those newly-arrived from Iran, Persian was familiar but foreign — a language of culture with a status somewhat similar to that of French at the Tsarist court in nineteenth-century Russia. Persian played the same role in Central Asia during the fourteenth and fifteenth centuries, and it is important to remember this when thinking about Babur. Babur spoke Chagatay Turkish, composed one of the prose masterpieces of the language, and created an inspired body of Turkish poetry. Nevertheless, like Timur and the other Turkic-Mongol rulers and nobles of Central Asia, Babur accepted the paramount role of Persian in culture and administration.

¹⁰ M. Mujeeb, *The Indian Muslims*, (London, George Allen and Unwin, Ltd., 1967), pp. 404–08.

¹¹ M. Zaki, "Organization of Islamic Learning Under the Sayyids and Lodis," *Medieval India*, 4, (1977), pp. 1–9.

¹² *Ibid.*

The Il-Khanids, that branch of the Mongols that came to rule in Iran during the thirteenth and fourteenth centuries, fell under the influence of Persian administrators. Like the Mongol states in Russia and China, the Il-Khanid state in Iran became virtually independent in the years following Chinggis Khan's death. Initially, the Il-Khanid rulers maintained their nomadic philosophy and showed a good deal of antagonism to agriculture and settled life. Soon, however, Persian administrators convinced the Mongol rulers of the utility of centralized government, the superiority of urban life and culture, and the advantages of encouraging agriculture and trade. This trend reached its culmination during the reign of Ghazan (1295–1304). His vizier was Rashid al-Din, famous as an historian and administrator, and spiritual descendant of the great Seljuk chief minister Nizam al-Mulk. Under Rashid al-Din's direction, Ghazan reorganized the bureaucracy and reformed the system of taxation and, partly as a result, agricultural production increased dramatically. During this period also the Mongol rulers and their followers began serious patronage of the arts and sciences.

Although Turkish was the mother tongue of Timur and his followers, the language of culture and state was Persian. Timur's court secretaries were drawn, for the most part, from those fluent in Persian. A few Turkish scribes, who wrote Chagatay Turkic in the Uighur script, were employed, and they are said to have composed a history in verse. No copies of this work have survived, however, and the major histories of Timur's reign are all in Persian.¹³

Timur himself, although illiterate, was neither unlearned nor uncultured. He spoke both Persian and Turkish and maintained a large library. Scholars read to him books on medicine, astronomy, history, mathematics, law, and theology, and he engaged them in long and lively discussions. He loved chess and developed a keen appreciation of the fine arts. He amassed a large collection of illustrated manuscripts, patronized sculptors, musicians, painters, architects, and craftsmen, and erected mosques, palaces, gardens, and markets in and around Samarkand, his capital.¹⁴

¹³ Hilda Hookham, *Tamburlaine the Conqueror*, (London, Hodder and Stoughton, 1962), pp. 319–21.

¹⁴ Ibid., pp. 79–81; V. V. Barthold, *Four Studies in the History of Central Asia*, I–III, trans. V. T. Minorsky (Leiden, E. J. Brill, 1956), I, 60; II, 22–23, 39–41; Cherefeddin Ali of Yazdi, *The History of Timur-Bec*, I–II, trans. into

Timur's successors, unable to match his military exploits, turned increasingly to artistic, intellectual, and scientific pursuits. Ulugh Beg, his grandson and master of Samarqand, presided over a court filled with musicians, dancers, poets, and architects. Ulugh Beg's name is remembered, however, because of his devotion to science. The exact sciences had been promoted in Iran under the Mongols, and Ulugh Beg erected an observatory in Samarqand where he and his men produced an impressive collection of works on astronomy.¹⁵ Herat, during the reign of Sultan Husain Mirza (1473–1506), another of Timur's descendants, was home to Jami (one of the three or four greatest poets of the Persian language), Bihzad (probably the greatest of all Persian painters), and Mir Ali Shir (the premier poet in Chagatay Turkic).¹⁶

Babur's father, Umar Shaikh Mirza, was a man of sensitivity and culture and a major influence on his son. He had, Babur wrote, a poetic nature and was influenced by Yunas Khan and Khwajah Ubaid Allah Ahrari.¹⁷ Yunas Khan, was Umar Shaikh's father-in-law (Babur's grandfather) and a direct descendant of Chinggis Khan. He had little taste for fighting or governing and had lived the early part of his life in exile in Badakshan, acquiring the polish of a Persian gentleman. He studied for twelve years under the renowned scholar and historian Sharif al-Din Yazdi, author of the *Zafar Namah*, and became a scholar of history, theology, and law as well as an accomplished calligrapher, painter, and singer. Ahrari, the famous sufi, guided Umar Shaikh Mirza along the pathways of Islamic mysticism. Under the direction of these men, Umar Shaikh studied the classics of the culture: the Quran (in Arabic), and Jami's *Masnawi*, Firdausi's *Shahnamah*, and the quintets of Nizami and Khusrao, all in Persian.¹⁸

Babur soon demonstrated that he was among the most talented of the Timurids. As a man of letters, he is best known for the *Babur-Namah*,

French by Pétis de la Croix, trans. into English by Anon. (London, 1723), I, 193; II, 142.

¹⁵ Barthold, *Four Studies*, vol. II.

¹⁶ Ibid., vol. III.

¹⁷ Zahir'ud-din Muhammed Babur Padshah Ghazi, *Babur-Nama*, trans. Annette Susannah Beveridge (London, Luzac and Co., 1922; reprint ed., New Delhi, Oriental Books Reprint Corp., 1970), p. 15.

¹⁸ Muhammad Abdu'l Ghani, *A History of Persian Language and Literature at the Mughal Court*, I–III, (Allahabad, The Indian Press, Ltd., 1929–30), I, 6–11.

one of the masterpieces of Turkic prose. He produced a body of poetry in Chagatay that was second in quality and inspiration only to that of Mir Ali Shir. He invented a new style of Turkic verse, produced a work on Turkic prosody, and wrote a book on jurisprudence.¹⁹ He was also an accomplished poet in Persian, superior to most of the nobles and the equal of the average mystical court poet. His verse showed the influence of Sa'adi, Hafiz, and Jami,²⁰ and his comments on the poetry of his contemporaries were particularly acute. He had apparently learned a good deal of Arabic, the composition of a book on the philosophy of law suggesting a fluency and competency beyond the ordinary.

Babur was an enthusiastic builder who erected mosques, palaces, baths, wells, and tanks. It is as a builder of gardens, however, that he is best known. In India he introduced the Central Asian style of garden with running water, trees, and flowers. He was also a skilled calligraphist and developed a new style of script called the *khatt-i baburi* in which the letters were written separately and unjoined. He knew the work of Bihzad, the great painter, and showed an intelligent interest in other artists and styles. His comments on instruments and players show a sophisticated understanding of music.

Babur's children – Hindal, Kamran Mirza, Muhammad Askar and Gulbadan Begum – were skillful poets and Humayun, his son and successor, produced a diwan of poetry.²¹ Babur's friends, rivals, and followers were also interested in the arts, and we find throughout the *Babur-Namah* comments on the poetry, prose, calligraphy, painting, and musicianship of these men.

The Emperor Akbar has been called "illiterate," and it is probably true that as was the case with Timur, Akbar's abilities to read and write were limited. Nevertheless, he had a great library, said to contain over 26,000 volumes, and works of poetry, literature, and history were read to him regularly. He had a strong memory and learned significant portions of the poetry of Hafiz and Rumi. He was curious, intelligent, and spoke a stylish Persian, reciting both Hindi and Persian poetry at court and composing verses extemporaneously in both languages. He was the

¹⁹ Mirza Muhammad Haidar Dughlat, *The Tarikh-i Rashidi: A History of the Moghuls of Central Asia*, ed. by N. Elias, trans. E. Dennison Ross (reprint ed.; Patna, Academica Asiatica, 1973), pp. 173–74.

²⁰ Ghani, *History of Persian Language*, I, 49–50.

²¹ A. Schimmel, "Babur Padishah, The Poet, With an Account of the Poetical Talent in His Family, *Islamic Culture*, 34, (1960), pp. 125–38.

first emperor to be born in India and his library contained no Turkic books. Akbar exhibited a strong interest in music, calligraphy, and painting and patronized a distinguished company of poets, historians, calligraphers, philosophers, theologians, physicians, painters, and musicians. Akbar may not have been able to read or write but he was certainly educated and highly cultured.²²

Like the emperors, the princes and great amirs of the Mughal court were an accomplished group. The *Mirza Namah*, an eighteenth century guide to noble behavior, stressed the need for a good education and the habit of correct speech: "In society he should try to guard against the shame of committing any mistake in conversation, for such incorrectness in speech is considered a great fault in a Mirza."²³

For princes and great amirs as for "men of the pen" command of the language and knowledge of literature were the primary virtues. Men of culture must have committed a good deal of Arabic and Persian verse to memory and be able to interject it into conversation and state documents at will. Abd al-Rahim Khan-i Khanan, for example, a great amir under Akbar and Jahangir, had mastered Persian, Arabic, Turkic, Sanskrit, and Hindi and could compose poetry in each, though he was particularly skilled in Persian and Hindi. Famed for his facility at translation, he rendered the *Babur-Namah* into Persian and translated court documents from Persian to Hindi at sight. He was unsurpassed in *insha* (diplomatic correspondence) and once drafted a letter of introduction for Akbar's ambassador to the court of Abdullah Khan Uzbek, ruler of Khurasan, that drew raves from the Uzbek court.²⁴

The great men of the Mughal court refined the skills of the "men of the pen," raising them to a pitch of perfection never before achieved. Secretaries, superintendents, and administrators had neither the talent, the training, nor the wealth to reach the cultural ideal, while emperors, princes, and great amirs had the education, leisure, and resources to express what was beautiful, graceful, and valued. The Mughal court was the final arbiter of taste, the place where the most talented poets, historians, calligraphers, musicians, dancers, painters, and singers performed. At court, competition was great and critical acumen keen, and

²² Ghani, *History of Persian Language*, III, pp. 10–36.

²³ Mirza Kamran, *The Mirza Namah*, trans. M. Hidayat Husain, *Journal of the Asiatic Society of Bengal*, 9, n. s. (1913), pp. 1–13.

²⁴ Chhotubhai Ranchhodji Naik, *Abd'r-Rahim Khan-i Khanan and His Literary Circle*, (Ahmedabad, Gujarat University, 1966), pp. 228–34.

the artist who captivated this audience had scaled the pinnacle of success. Such artists were lavishly rewarded and became valued members of imperial and great amiri households.

Men of the Sword

Emperors, princes, and great amirs were not effete, overcultured courtiers, skilled at reciting poetry, composing state documents, judging the dancing and singing of courtesans, and nothing more. They were accomplished soldiers as well, trained in horseback riding, archery, sword fighting, and the use of firearms, able to command the respect of their troops and to lead them in battle. In the *Babur-Namah* we see the strength, prowess, and military skill of the emperor and his men as they ride, fight, hunt, and shoot. Mughal great men combined the skills and talents of the “men of the pen” with those of the “men of the sword.”

The ancestors of the “men of the sword” were probably the Seljuk Turks, a group of nomadic warriors who overran much of West Asia in the early part of the eleventh century. They adopted Islam and were converted to settled rule by the Persian administrators of the area. Under their tutelage, the Seljuk rulers adopted the trappings of kings and gave up irregular raiding and plunder for the rewards of routinized tax-collection. Other nomadic warriors (the Mongols and Timurid Turks, for example) invaded West Asia during the following centuries and were domesticated and absorbed as well. From that time forward a split developed between the military elite who ruled and protected the state and the clerks and managers who ran the administrative apparatus, a split that was reflected in the categories “men of the sword” and “men of the pen.”

Under Babur and Humayun “men of the sword” were lesser chieftains and individual cavalymen. They were of middling-rank and below, commanding at best a few men, and, in most cases, responsible for no one but themselves and a few servants. Such men were neither systematically recruited, trained, nor ranked, and we do not know much about them.

Akbar undertook a reorganization of the “men of the sword,” establishing rules for recruitment, pay, rank, weaponry, armor, and horses. Mughal “men of the sword” were commanders and cavalymen. These men were specialists, devoting their lives to the arts of war. Commanders or low-ranking mansabdars were the most important of the Mughal

“men of the sword.” Holding ranks from 20–400 zat, these men filled minor posts in imperial, princely, or great amiri contingents. They were, however, disbarred from higher positions by their educational and cultural deficiencies.

Ahdis or single cavalrymen served in the emperor’s private bodyguard and cavalrymen served in princely and amiri households. Cavalrymen, who made up the bulk of the “men of the sword,” received a good salary. They were paid 200 rupees a year, out of which they had to provide horses, armor, weapons, and servants. Theirs was an honorable profession in Mughal India and both ahadis and cavalrymen were respectable men in Muslim society. Many of them, in fact, rose from the ranks to fill posts in the lower reaches of the mansabdari system.²⁵

To enter Mughal service “men of the sword” required patrons: blood relatives or fellow members of tribes, castes, or ethnic groups. A commander who wanted mansabdari rank was introduced to the *mir bakshi* (paymaster general) by his patron and, if found properly armed and supplied, was presented to the emperor. Ahadis also needed the personal approval of the emperor but individual cavalrymen were checked less carefully. Recruited by their amirs, they were examined by the bakshi’s office and then entered on the rolls.

“Men of the pen” wore heavy, cumbersome body armor. The central piece, for those who could afford it, was a cuirass with a quilted jacket beneath. Most cavalrymen, however, put on long, heavy, quilted coats which stopped arrows and deadened sword blows. Cotton trousers fastened with a shawl covered the lower body. Mansabdars wore steel helmets while cavalrymen protected their heads with folds of quilted cloth. Mailed gloves and leggings were worn by the well-to-do. Strong, well-trained horses were indispensable, and mansabdars put armor on the chests and hindquarters of their mounts. For most cavalrymen, however, heavy quilts provided the only protection.²⁶

“Men of the sword” handled their weapons with skill. Since Mughal cavalrymen did most of their fighting at close quarters, swords, lances, and daggers were important. Scimitars, short swords with curved blades, and long straight swords with broad blades hung from belts or were slung over the shoulder. On his left arm or over his shoulder a

²⁵ William Irvine, *The Army of The Indian Moghuls*, (reprint ed.; Delhi, Eurasia Publishing House Pvt. Ltd., 1982), pp. 3–23.

²⁶ *Ibid.*, pp. 62–71.

cavalryman carried a shield of steel or hide. Some men used battle axes while others wielded bayonets and javelins; many carried long, heavy lances or iron. Daggers came into play in hand-to-hand fighting.

Although firearms had been available in Mughal India from the late sixteenth century, they were cumbersome and difficult to use and the bow and arrow remained the major long-distance weapon of the Mughal cavalry until at least the middle of the eighteenth century. Bows were four feet long and double-curved, made of horn, wood, bamboo, ivory, or steel, and strung with catgut. Bowmen carried arrows of wood or steel in quivers slung over their shoulders, leather guards protected their arms, and rings of steel guarded their thumbs and fingers. There are many treatises of the eighteenth century devoted entirely to archery, and Bernier observed that a Mughal archer could loose six arrows before a musketeer could fire twice. The Mughals rated the sword better than the dagger, the spear better than the sword, and the bow and arrow superior to them both.²⁷

No regular drill or exercise was required of "men of the sword." Great amirs did not schedule maneuvers or mount war games, and so cavalrymen in amiri contingents and low-ranking mansabdars kept themselves in fighting trim by individual drilling and exercise. To build strength and stamina they exercised with dumb-bells, heavy sticks of wood, clubs, and chainbows. Daily rehearsal of a coordinated sequence of movements called *kasarat* developed agility and quickness. These men wrestled and engaged in mock fights with heavy sticks and shields, they jousting at tent-pegs with lances, shot arrows at small targets while galloping full speed, and trained their horses to stand on their hind legs and jump forward in a maneuver designed to attack elephants.²⁸

"Men of the sword," however, had no monopoly on the arts of war in Mughal India. Timurid rulers, from the great conqueror himself to the Mughal emperor Akbar, were all skilled soldiers. According to Yazdi, Timur concentrated in his early years on the "science of arms" and spent a great deal of time riding, racing, sword fighting, and hunting.²⁹ He was one of the great generals of history, and he led by example. Babur

²⁷ Ibid., pp. 73–102; François Bernier, *Travels in The Mughal Empire: 1656–68*, ed. Archibald Constable, trans. Irving Brock (London, Constable's Oriental Miscellany, 1891; reprint ed., Delhi, S. Chand and Co., 1968), p. 48.

²⁸ Irvine, *Army*, pp. 182–89.

²⁹ Yazdi, *Timur-Bec*, I, xxvii.

developed his soldierly skills early, practicing with the sword, musket, bow and arrow, and becoming a superb horseman. Evidence of his strength, endurance, and military prowess abounds in the *Babur-Namah*: he marched through floods, rode without water for great distances, and fought his way into Samarqand, capturing the city with only five hundred men.

From the early fifteenth century in Central Asia to the early seventeenth century in India, Timurid nobles demonstrated considerable proficiency in the arts of war. The great men of his day were skilled with musket and sword and Babur wrote with enthusiasm and knowledge of their accomplishments in battle.³⁰ For him, the soldier's art was just as important as the poet's and just as worthy of comment and criticism.

The great amirs of Akbar's court were skilled in horseback riding, archery, sword-fighting, and firearms. They developed the skills, stamina, and strength to prevail in individual combat and to lead by example in battle. With greater resources and better training, they raised the art of war to a new level.

For a great amir training began early. At about age nine he learned the use of matchlocks and pistols, the fundamentals of archery and horsemanship, and was introduced to wrestling.³¹ In succeeding years he followed a regime of exercise, training, and competition that developed his endurance and ability and whetted his appetite for battle. Wrestling, a national pastime in Iran, was a favorite activity in Mughal India. Young men learned a variety of holds and techniques which they tried out in local competitions. Lucknow wrestling masters, for example, taught special tricks designed to overcome deficiencies in weight or height.³² Sword-fighting skills were perfected in stickfighting, the Indian techniques having been originally developed in Arabia and Iran. Training in hand-to-hand combat — how to defend against dagger attacks or how to disarm an opponent with a handkerchief — was included also.³³ Hunts, races, and games of polo developed horsemanship, and

³⁰ Babur, *Babur-Namah*, pp. 16, 26, 112, 259, 276.

³¹ Zahiruddin Malik, "Some Aspects of Mughal Culture During the First Half of the Eighteenth Century," *Studies in Islam*, 2, (1965), p. 38.

³² Abdul Halim Sharer, *Lucknow: The last Phase of an Oriental Culture*, trans. and ed. E. S. Harcourt and Fakhir Hussain (Boulder, Col., Westview Press, 1976), p. 113.

³³ *Ibid.*, pp. 109–15.

practice at the range and in the saddle sharpened skills in archery and firearms. Aurangzeb advised his sons:

If you are on a journey, but it is a day of halt . . . spend 48 minutes of the morning in archery and musket practice.

Gradually make yourself perfect in the habit of wearing arms. Let your sweat dry before you take off your coat and lie down, lest you should fall ill.³⁴

Armor and weapons were highly prized in Mughal India, and emperors, princes, and great amirs maintained large collections of elaborately decorated and embellished pieces. Of finely-tempered steel, the cuirass of the great men included a breastplate, backplate, and two smaller pieces for the sides – all carved and engraved, decorated with tassels, and held together by leather straps. Underneath was a coat of mail with mail sleeves. Helmets were carved with visors and noseguards and a network of mail which protected the neck. A steel gauntlet connected to a steel armpiece covered the sword arm while iron legpieces and mail stockings warded off blows to the legs and ankles. The horses of the great men were armored front, back, head, and neck with crafted steel pieces; their trappings were adorned with gold and silver and embroidered blankets covered their backs.

The swords of emperors, princes, and great amirs, like those of cavalymen, were short and curved for slashing and close combat, and long and straight for heavy cutting and thrusting. The swords of great men differed, however, in being of tempered steel, richly engraved, and able to carry a finer edge. Daggers and knives were finely made.

From the late seventeenth century onward, emperors, princes, and great amirs do not seem to have made much use of the bow and arrow in battle. They left these weapons, by and large, to the “men of the sword” under their command while they themselves used firearms instead. Matchlocks had long carved barrels (some of Akbar’s were 66 inches) and a tripod was often needed for firing. They required powder flasks, bullet pouches, priming horns, matchcords, flints, and steels, and it is no wonder that an extra servant was needed to carry and service them. Flintlocks were not common until the late eighteenth century, having been introduced by the Europeans, and percussion weapons were not avail-

³⁴ Aurangzeb, *Adab-i 'Alamgiri*, trans. Jadunath Sarkar in *Studies in Aurangzeb's Reign*, pp. 40–41.

able at all. Pistols are not mentioned in the *A'in*, and they do not seem to have been employed in India until the early eighteenth century. They were weapons of the wealthy and required a servant for carrying, loading, and servicing.³⁵

Babur had learned the use of small cannons and joined muskets from the Persians and Ottomans and had placed an Ottoman contingent in charge of this artillery. His use of these weapons was particularly effective against the Afghans at the first battle of Panipat in 1526. Cannon were found in the imperial household from Akbar's time but the Mughals never really learned to deploy them to advantage. The bigger the better was the Mughal principle, and they manufactured heavy, immobile cannons which were decorated and named but which could not be fired rapidly and were easily captured. Light artillery, small field pieces of brass, were mounted on carriages, wheeled from place to place, and fired rapidly. After Babur, however, the Mughals seemed to lose their sense of tactics, and they were never able to use these pieces very effectively.³⁶

Emperors, princes, and great amirs mastered the skills of individual combat but they do not seem to have devoted much thought to strategy and training. How then did Mughal commanders develop battle plans, how did they train their troops in the tactics of mass warfare? One answer is that they did not develop plans and that their troops were relatively untrained. The emperor Aurangzeb, for example, complained that he had not been taught how to besiege towns, take fortresses, and fight pitched battles.³⁷ This is not the whole answer, however. Emperors, princes, and great amirs did engage in large-scale maneuvers of a sort, giving cavalymen and their commanders some experience in large-scale, set-piece combat.

The early Mughal emperors, like their Timurid and Mongol ancestors, spent a great deal of time travelling, moving from place to place, controlling subordinates and renewing the patron-client ties between them and their followers. Babur controlled Samarqand and Kabul for short periods only, and he was often in camp, recovering from a recent defeat and

³⁵ Irvine, *Army*, pp. 62–109; *The Indian Heritage: Court Life and Arts Under Mughal Rule* (London, Victoria and Albert Museum, 1982), pp. 134–38.

³⁶ Irvine, *Army*, pp. 113–47.

³⁷ Bernier, *Travels*, p. 161; Niccolao Manucci, *Storia do Mogor*, I–IV, trans. William Irvine (London, John Murray, 1907–08; reprint ed., Calcutta, Editions Indian, 1965), II, 29–33.

ouster and putting together a plan for reconquest. Even in the last, relatively tranquil years in India, he did not settle down and we find him building gardens not palaces in Agra. Humayun, Babur's son and successor, after devoting the first ten years of his reign to subduing the Afghans and Rajputs, was driven from the subcontinent and compelled to wander, with brief stops in Iran and Afghanistan, from 1540–46. The rest of the dynasty from Akbar on spent nearly forty percent of their time on tour. Although Bahadur Shah (1707–12) was extreme, he illustrates this aspect of Mughal rule. In the five years of his reign, Bahadur Shah never slept within four walls, he always stayed in a tent.

Peripatetic rule was common among the ancestors of the Mughals. Chinggis Khan was a nomad and his Yasa or law is said to have contained the injunction: "Mongols are not to become established in cities."³⁸ Timur also moved constantly and, although he built mosques, baths, palaces, and gardens in and around Samarqand, he never stayed more than a couple of weeks in any one of his residences. More often that not, in fact, he camped with his army in a meadow outside the walls.³⁹

Mughal emperors toured to conquer new areas, to reconquer old, to quell rebellions, to attend festivals, to escape the heat of mid-summer North India, and to hunt. Akbar declared:

"A badshah should concentrate continually on conquest, lest his neighbors take up arms against him."⁴⁰ And Abu al-Fazl wrote of Akbar's travelling: "Since the expeditions of just rulers are a source of repose for mankind and a daily marketplace of justice, the auspicious mind [Akbar] often turned toward travelling and hunting (*sair va shikar*)."⁴¹

In camp the great men were better able to practice the arts of war. A good part of each day was spent on horseback, refining skills in archery, swordsmanship, and firearms. Some of this was actual combat: many expeditions were intended to quell minor disturbances, pacify rebellious zamindars, and show the flag in fractious parts of the empire.

³⁸ "Tarikh-i Guzida," St. Petersburg University Manuscript no. 153, p. 472 quoted in W. Barthold, *Turkestan Down to the Mongol Invasion*, trans. H. A. R. Gibb, 2 d. ed. (London, Luzac and Co., 1958), p. 461, fn. 5.

³⁹ *Narrative of the Embassy of Ruy Gonzales de Clavijo to the Court of Timur at Samarcand: 1403–06* by Clements R. Markham (London, Hakluyt Society, 1859), pp. 238–44.

⁴⁰ Abu al-Fazl, *Ain-i Akbari*, I–II, ed. H. Blochmann (Calcutta, Asiatic Society of Bengal, 1867–77), II, 244.

⁴¹ Abu al-Fazl, *Akbar Nahmah*, ed. Agha Ahmad Ali and Maulavi 'Abd al-Rahim, I–III, (Calcutta, Asiatic Society of Bengal, 1873–86), II, 212.

Nevertheless, the principal method of developing the soldier's art on tour was hunting. In many parts of Northern and Central India imperial hunting preserves had been established, and emperors, princes, and great amirs spent significant portions of many expeditions finding, riding down, shooting, and killing wild animals. Hunting tigers and lions was a royal prerogative, and only a few great amirs were allowed to participate. Ordinarily, the great cats were shot by musket or bow and arrow from the backs of elephants but sometimes they were approached on horseback. Elephants were hunted from the backs of other elephants; deer, rhinoceroses, blue bulls, wild asses, and cheetah were chased on horseback and shot with bow and arrow or matchlock. The Mughals trained cheetah to kill deer and blue bulls, employed packs of hunting dogs, and took up falconry, a sport that had a long history in Arabia and Iran.⁴²

Hunts were of two kinds: small and informal, spur-of-the-moment, with only a few men; and large and well-organized, involving the mansabdars and cavalymen of the camp. The first was a common occurrence on tour. Emperors, princes, and great amirs would halt for several days in order to hunt nearby and would often go for a brief shoot at the end of a day's march.

The other variety of hunt, however, involved a great number of men, was staged in one of the imperial preserves, and was carefully organized and coordinated. Called a *qamargah* (moonshaped) hunt or a *shikar-i jarga* (circular hunt), this was a large-scale maneuver. A great many cavalymen (as many as 50,000 sometimes) were deployed in a huge circle. At a signal they began to move forward, contracting the circle, beating the underbrush, and trapping the game within. When the circle had closed and the animals had become closely confined, the ruler and his entourage entered the ring and began a general slaughter. The encircling cavalymen shot and killed those animals which tried to escape and those which remained after the great men had left.⁴³ The Mughals, descendants through Babur of Timur and Chinggis Khan, organized their hunt after the Mongol pattern. The Persian historian Juvaini reveals the Mongol hunt, like the Mughal, to be a kind of war-game, an exercise for

⁴² For typical hunts of the period see Abu al-Fazl, *Akbar-Namah*, II, 281–82 and Nur al-Din Jahangir, *Tuzuk-i Jahangiri*, trans. A. Rogers and H. Beveridge (London, Royal Asiatic Society, 1909–14), pp. 39–40, 57, 59–60.

⁴³ For the *qamargah* hunt see Anand Ram, "Mir'at al-Istilah," Persian Manuscript Collection, Or. 1813, British Museum, fol. 183 b.

developing the coordination, discipline, courage, and individual skills of large scale battle.

According to Juvaini:

[Chinggis Khan] has given careful attention to the matter of the hunt and has said that the hunting of wild animals is a proper occupation for amirs and that instruction and training [in it] is necessary for warriors and men at arms; not only for the game, but also to become ... familiarized with handling the bow and enduring hardships ... any time the khan undertakes a great hunt [*shikar-i buzurg*] ... he orders the soldiers ... to prepare to hunt ... For one, two, or three months they maintain a hunting ring [*halqa-i shikar*] ... and if unexpectedly, an animal should escape, an exhaustive inquiry as to the cause is made and amirs of 1,000, 100, and 10 are beaten and often even put to death because of it. And if, for example, a man does not keep to the lines, but takes a step backwards or forwards, he is severely punished and never excused ... when the ring has contracted so that the wild animals cannot move, first the khan rides in with his retinue ... then ... the princes, the noyans, the commanders, and the soldiers ... now war—with its killing, counting of the dead, and sparing of survivors—is quite similar and analogous in every detail ... ⁴⁴

Timur and his men arranged large-scale hunts in this manner,⁴⁵ and Babur also planned hunts in the *qamargah* style. Discussing the placement of his followers in battle and during the hunt, Babur wrote: “Precisely as Chinggis Khan laid down his rules, so the Mughals still observe them.”⁴⁶

Conclusion

Emperors, princes, and great amirs were the embodiment of high culture in Mughal India. They mastered the basic skills of the men both of the pen and of the sword, refining and developing these two aspects of courtly culture and expressing in a more elegant, elaborate, and practiced form all that was valued at the Mughal court. Mughal “men of the

⁴⁴ Ala al-din Ata Malik-i Juwayni, *Tarikh-i Jahan Gusha*, ed. Mirza Muhammad, I–III, (London: Luzac and Co., 1912–37), I, 19–21. See also John Andrew Boyle, *The History of the World Conqueror*, I–II, (Manchester, Manchester University Press, 1958), I, 27.

⁴⁵ Yazdi, *Timur-Bec*, I, 268–69.

⁴⁶ Babur, *Babur Namah*, p. 155.

pen" did not have the education or resources to cultivate the full range of the fine arts. Their expertise was confined, by and large, to fluency in Persian and mastery of the prose of state documents, chronicles, memoranda, and diplomatic correspondence. Their knowledge of Persian, furthermore, was limited to the standard authors, and their poetical compositions were perfunctory. Painting, music, dance, and architecture were beyond them.

The great men, on the other hand, had interests that were catholic, deep, and abiding, their abilities frequently rose above the ordinary, and because of their training they were able to recognize talent. A grounding in Islamic theology and Arabic poetry and prose enabled them to remain in touch with their heritage. Their knowledge of Persian was fluent and profound, and they composed acceptable, often praiseworthy specimens of poetry. Their prose was refined and elegant. In addition, individual emperors, princes, and great amirs exhibited skill in calligraphy, painting, architecture, music, and dance. But it was their appreciation of these other art forms, their ability to recognize and reward genius, that was crucial.

The rulers mastered the arts of war as well. Becoming expert in the basic military skills, they soon surpassed the "men of the sword" who had neither the resources, the training, nor the opportunities to match them. Their horses were inferior, their equipment rudimentary, and their roles subordinate. Their military skills were confined, by and large, to the sword, dagger, and lance in close combat and the bow and arrow at longer range. Although discipline was lax and coordination minimal in Mughal armies, "men of the sword" found themselves circumscribed, their roles limited, and they were not able to fully express themselves.

The great men, on the other hand, developed expertise across the full range of the military arts. They were given extensive training in wrestling, in the use of the lance, and in hand-to-hand combat with sword and dagger. Archery masters drilled them in the use of the bow and arrow. Their horses were well-bred and carefully trained, strong and able to endure, and since the great men did not have to worry about replacements, they could ride and fight with verve and abandon. Their armor was well-made and ornate; it provided more protection and was less cumbersome than that of the "men of the sword," and it enabled them to move more easily in battle. These men became expert marksmen as well, having the resources and leisure to master the cumbersome and expensive weapons.

Emperors, princes, and great amirs were the only military men to spend any time on tactics and training. They organized the *qamargah* hunt, making an effort to develop some minimal coordination. In the arts of war as in the arts of peace, they patronized the able and talented. They rewarded achievement in battle, recommending for promotion those who displayed skill and courage. They also provided openings for European innovations in firearms and tactics, especially in the use of infantry.

The emperors, princes, and great amirs combined the abilities and attributes of the two cultural styles, summing up and expressing in a new, elegant, and unique way the courtly culture of Mughal India. That culture had a long history. Nizam al-Mulk, the great Seljuk wazir, wrote that a king should possess "... integrity, manliness, bravery, horsemanship, knowledge, [skill in] the use of various kinds of arms, and accomplishment in several arts."⁴⁷ Umar Shaikh Mirza, Babur's father, had, on the one hand, a poetic nature, a good knowledge of Persian prose and poetry, and the ability to recite verses while, on the other, he was a skilled swordsman, a middling archer, and an experienced captain.⁴⁸ Sultain Husain Mirza, ruler of Herat, was an accomplished swordsman ("no man of Timur could match him in slashing swords"), a man of great endurance and strength ("he swam the Gurgan ... in his guerilla days and gave a party of Uzbegs a good beating"), and a good general but he was also a talented poet (he had composed a Turkic diwan), and a sophisticated patron of musicians, dancers, poets, and painters.⁴⁹ An historian of the late seventeenth century described one of Aurangzeb's great amirs: "In his assemblies the topics of conversation were mostly verse, prose, sword, jewel, horse, elephant, and aphrodisiacs."⁵⁰ And Abu al-Fazl wrote about an important noble of Akbar's court: "Khwaja Abd al-Majid, because of his ability, had been distinguished by the title of Asaf Khan, and had been raised from the pen [*qalam*] to the sword [*saif*] and had joined those who wear both the sword and the pen and are masters both of war and of peace."⁵¹

⁴⁷ *The Book of Government or Rules for Kings, The Siyasat-Namah or Siyar al-Muluk of Nizam al-Mulk*, trans. Hubert Darke (New Haven, Yale University Press, 1960), pp. 10–11.

⁴⁸ Babur, *Babur-Namah*, pp. 15–19.

⁴⁹ *Ibid.*, pp. 259–61.

⁵⁰ Muhammad Saqi Musta'idd Khan, *Ma'asir-i 'Alamqiri* (Calcutta, Asiatic Society of Bengal, 1873–75), p. 390.

⁵¹ Abu al-Fazl, *Akbar Namah*, II, 182.